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By Scott Waldman · Aug 17, 2026, 9:52 PM · [View in your browser](#)

Energy Secretary Chris Wright says about 9 million barrels of oil are moving through the Strait of Hormuz every day.

But nonpartisan oil tanker trackers say it's likely 7 million barrels at best, or more likely, closer to 5 million.

President Donald Trump has repeatedly said that the oil is flowing freely through the strait, which even before the war was a global energy chokepoint. On Monday, he told reporters at the White House that the U.S. has total control over the strait and that "we're taking out millions of barrels of oil a week."

"The strait is open and the oil prices are coming down, and they will continue to come down unless we decide to do something more drastic than what we've been doing," Trump said.

But experts say the Trump administration's figures cannot be trusted because there's no data that shows that volume of oil is actually moving through the strait.

It appears as if Wright was "just pulling a number out of the air," said Matt Smith, director of Commodity Research at Kpler, a leading firm tracking tanker movements.

"The reality is that Iran has the leverage, Iran has the control," he said. "The only tankers that are really passing through the Strait of Hormuz are those that are operating through Iranian waters."

The recent peak might be as much as 7 million barrels a day, said Rory Johnston, founder of Commodity Context, a Canada-based oil markets analytics firm. He questioned Wright's claims about 20 million barrels leaving the region, however, and said the administration has not "earned the benefit of the doubt on oil market estimates."

On Monday, Wright told Fox News that more oil is escaping the Strait of Hormuz than data trackers realize, claiming that only the Trump administration has the accurate count of tankers leaving the region because "ours aren't estimates, we have the actual data."

The White House referred questions to the Energy Department. An agency spokesperson referred to Wright's X post that stated "Many private businesses undercount the number of ships leaving the Strait of Hormuz due to ships moving covertly through the waterway."

The total volume of global crude that is available on any given day sets oil prices, which in turn shapes grocery costs, transportation expenses, consumer spending and much more. In short, the more crude that moves, the better it is for affordability everywhere, which is a boon for politicians running on that

message in November's elections.

Before the war, an average of almost 140 ships a day crossed through the strait, transporting fertilizer, aluminum, helium liquefied natural gas and about 20 million barrels a day of crude. On Sunday, just 3 ships crossed the strait, according to data from commodities tracking firm Kpler. Last week, only 95 ships total crossed the strait, Kpler found.

And oil markets are showing signs of growing weary of the administration's promises that a return to normal is just around the corner. Global oil prices – which have repeatedly dropped on optimistic projections from Trump and other administration officials many times in the last five months – actually increased after Wright's post about covert ship movements.

Global Crude prices approached around \$90 a barrel on Monday. Meanwhile, the national average price for a gallon of gas in the U.S. is creeping back up, hitting \$4.067 on Monday, according to AAA, the highest it has ever been this late in the season.

To be sure, tracking the amount of tankers leaving the strait is challenging. Ships are turning off their transponders to avoid detection, satellite imaging has been compromised in some areas and the U.S. military is moving tankers under secretive conditions. But Smith said organizations like Kpler have now had months to adapt to the new operating environment and have adjusted accordingly with new methodology.

Though 9 million barrels seems like a stretch, there has been an uptick in the amount of crude escaping the strait in recent months, according to Michelle Bockmann, an analyst at Windward, a maritime intelligence firm. In July, data shows that up to 5 million barrels a day moved through the strait, compared to 4 million in June and 1.6 million in July, she said.

Still, Bockmann said, tracking the exact number of ships transiting the strait is getting harder because there are a growing number of "dark transits."

Last week, Mason Hamilton, vice president of economics and research at the American Petroleum Institute, summed up the current state of affairs for people tracking oil flows through the strait.

"Might as well just rename it Schrödinger's Strait..." he wrote on X, referring to the theory in quantum mechanics which holds that something can exist in multiple possible states until it is observed or measured.

Energy and Climate Mobility

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